Building clear sentences: simple, compound and complex

Understand it

A clause is a group of words with its own subject and verb. A sentence can have one clause (simple), two equal clauses (compound) or one main clause plus a dependent clause that cannot stand alone (complex).

Examiners reward a mix. Band 6 writers use mostly simple sentences joined with and or but; band 7 writers use complex sentences accurately and keep them clear. The aim is not long sentences, but controlled ones.

The rules

- A simple sentence has one clause: Cities are growing.
- A compound sentence joins two equal clauses with and, but, or, so: Cities are growing, but jobs are not.
- A complex sentence joins a main clause and a dependent clause with because, although, when, if, which: Cities are growing because people want better jobs.
- A band 7 essay mixes all three kinds. Too many short simple sentences sound weak; too many long ones become unclear.

All the words and forms you need

Join equal ideas (compound)	and · but · or · so · yet · nor
Dependent clauses: reason	because · since · as
Contrast	although · even though · though · while · whereas
Time	when · while · before · after · until · once · as soon as
Condition	if · unless · provided that · as long as
Extra information	which · who · where · whose

Where you use it

Writing: Open a paragraph with a complex sentence, then give examples in simple ones.

Speaking: Join your ideas with because, although and so, and your answer sounds longer and smoother.

Reading: In a long sentence, find the main clause first (who does what), then read the extra information.

More examples

- Many families move to cities, but housing there is expensive.

- Since online courses are cheap, more adults are returning to education.
- Unless governments invest in teachers, class sizes will keep growing.
- Once students leave school, many of them stop reading for pleasure.
- Exams, which test memory more than thinking, still dominate education.
- Although homeschooling is growing, most parents still prefer schools.

Common mistakes

Wrong	Right
✗ People use phones, they are useful.	✓ People use phones because they are useful.
✗ Because it is cheap.	✓ I prefer it because it is cheap.
✗ Although it is expensive, but many buy it.	✓ Although it is expensive, many people buy it.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. Why do people move to big cities? (use because and although)
2. What do you usually do after you finish your studies for the day? (use after / once)
3. Would you study abroad? (use if / unless)
4. Describe your school using a which clause.
5. What would you change about your town and why?

Writing practice

Rewrite this paragraph using one compound, one complex and one simple sentence: Children use phones. They use them a lot. It is bad for sleep. Parents should set limits.

Practice

1. Join: The city is crowded. Rents are high. (use and)

2. Join with although: Prices rose. Sales increased.

3. Join with because: She left early. She was tired.

4. Correct: Many students study abroad, they want a better future.

5. Add a clause with which: Online shopping is growing.

6. Correct: Although he was tired, but he continued.

Answers

1. The city is crowded, and rents are high.
2. Although prices rose, sales increased.
3. She left early because she was tired.
4. Many students study abroad because they want a better future.
5. Online shopping, which is convenient, is growing.
6. Although he was tired, he continued.